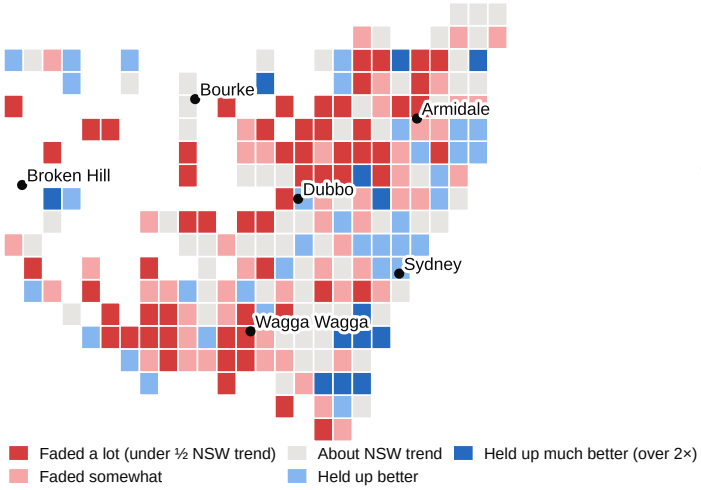
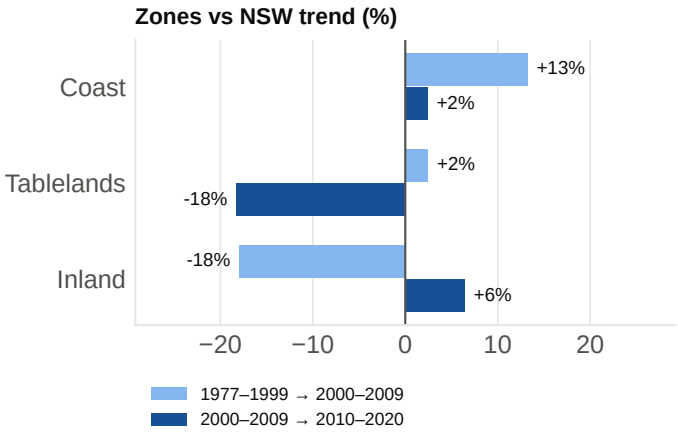
QUESTION 2

Are breeding declines concentrated in particular regions, habitats or ecological groups?

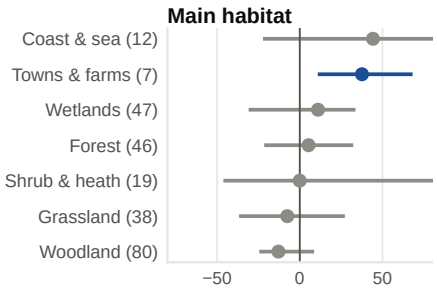
Breeding faded first inland, then on the tablelands; insect-eaters fared worst

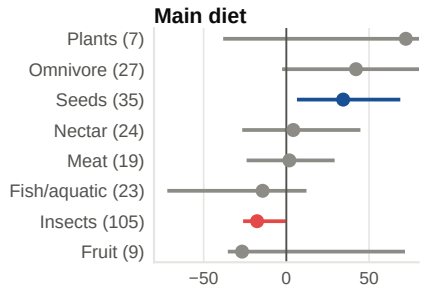
Change in breeding vs NSW trend: map 1977–1999 → 2000–2020; zones by step; groups 1977–1999 → 2010–2020

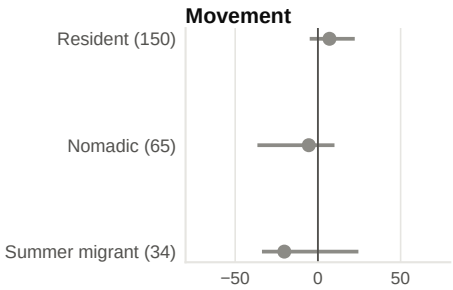




Groups: median % change vs typical species, 95% range (red = clearly lower)







KEY FINDINGS

- Breeding fell most inland from 1977–1999 to 2000–2009 (-18% vs NSW), then most on the tablelands to 2010–2020 (-18%).
- Map cells fading faster than NSW: 59% inland, 49% tablelands, 18% coast (222 cells).
- Clearly below typical: insect-eaters (-18%). Habitat groups do not differ by more than chance.

POSSIBLE CAUSES · OUR SPECULATION, NOT TESTED HERE

- Inland breeding dropped in the Millennium Drought decade and recovered after (+6% vs NSW): this fits drought, not lasting loss. The team's rainfall analysis can test it.
- Tablelands kept falling after 2010, before the 2017–19 drought: a slow pressure such as dying paddock trees and dieback fits better than one drought.
- Insect-eaters may be hit by fewer insects where grazing, pesticides and drought thin the ground layer.

Map: 1977–1999 vs 2000–2020 (team periods), 0.5° cells with at least 10 expected breeding records, species mix held fixed. The earlier version had 41 larger cells because it needed the same squares surveyed in three periods.